runs-an-over mark for the most of the innings. We had set ourselves a target of 280–90 and were on course to achieve it.

As I passed 80, the pressure started to build and I began to feel the burden of the hundred again. I did my best to put it out of my mind, but it was a truly difficult and frustrating period. I remember an over against Mashrafe Mortaza during the batting powerplay in which three shots I played should have gone for four. They were stopped by some really good fielding or they went straight to the fielders. On another day, I could have taken 12 from the over. On that day, I got nothing.

I had to counter the building pressure and somehow I played a shot for four when I was on 90 that calmed my nerves a little. Meanwhile Suresh Raina, who had come in to bat after Virat, was finding the boundary consistently, keeping the scoring rate up. I was now on 94 and, with another single in the same over, had come the closest to a hundred for a year.

In the forty-first over I took three more singles and was left needing just two more runs. They were perhaps the two most difficult runs of my career. Despite having scored ninety-nine international hundreds, I had experienced nothing like it. Determination, anxiety, relief – all of these feelings came together. I kept telling myself to stay focused and play each ball on merit. It was time to go back to basics and rely on skills I had practised all my life.

When I got to 99 by driving Shakib-al-Hasan to long off, I told myself that the situation demanded patience and it was no time for heroics. Shakib was getting the ball to spin and so when I faced him next I stepped out just a little to smother the turn. As the ball trundled to square leg, I jogged to my 100th international century.

I instantly felt drained. I removed my helmet and pointed to the flag on the front, indicating that I had done it for India. Then I looked at my bat and asked God why it had taken so long when my commitment had been steadfast throughout. More than anything, I was relieved. As I patted the tricolour on my helmet with my bat, I felt a tremendous sense of satisfaction. It gave me a sense of fulfilment that the first player to achieve the feat of scoring 100 international hundreds was an Indian.

Friends often say to me that my celebrations that day seemed rather muted. I remind them that I had been like that for over two decades. I have always preferred to be restrained, except on a few rare occasions. This is not to say I wasn’t proud. Of course I was. When I first played for